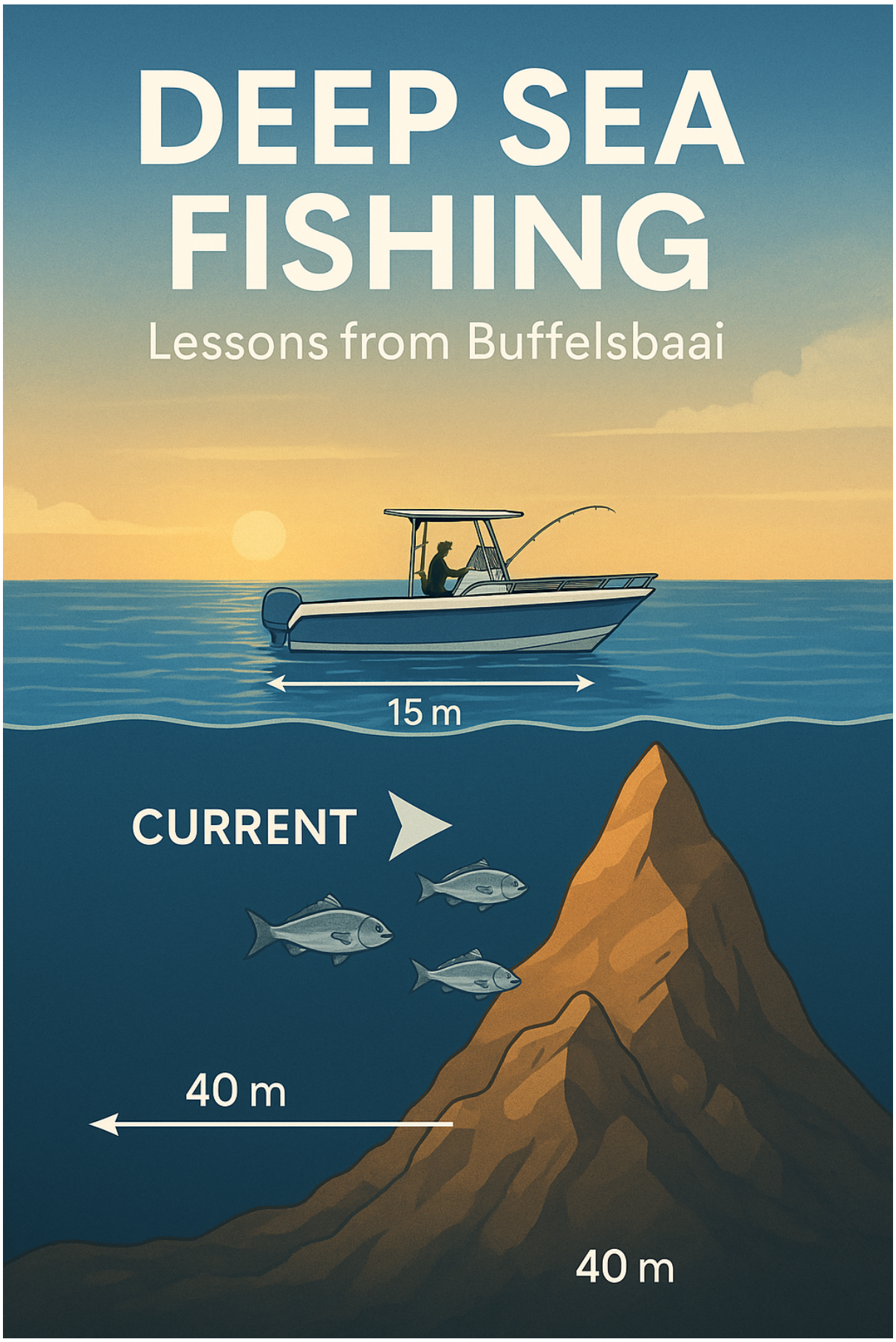
DEEP SEA FISHING

Lessons from Buffelsbaai



Saltwater Pages

by

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Please keep notes in your copies — the next release will be updated as we learn more together.

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS **2**

INTRODUCTION **5**

Why This Book? 5
The Buffelsbaai Advantage. 6
What Makes Deep Sea Fishing Unique Here 7
Who This Guide Is For. 8
How to Use This Book. 9

CHAPTER 1: WHEN THE OCEAN WHISPERS **10**

Temperature, Wind, and Water Movement. 11
Current: Your Best Ally and Worst Enemy 11
Swell & Depth Interaction 12
Moon and Tide: The Invisible Hand 13
The Decision Formula. 13

CHAPTER 2: ARSENAL ASSEMBLED **14**

Your line setup 14
For bait fishing 14
For jigging setups 15
Choosing Your Weapons 16
Jigs vs Bait. 16
Bait Strategy 17
Anchoring Like a Sniper. 18

CHAPTER 3: UNDERWATER EYES **20**

Bottom Lock vs Auto 20
Interpreting the Display. 20
Structure Is King. 21
Transducer Positioning. 21
Marking and Notes. 22

CHAPTER 4: UNDERWATER CHESS **23**

Red Roman 23
Steenbras. 23
Kob 24
Yellowbelly 24
Musselcracker. 25
Miss Lucy 25
Santer 25
Romans 26

CHAPTER 5: TACTICAL EDGE **27**

Filtering with Big Bait 27
Targeting the Front of Structure. 27
Using Scent to Your Advantage 28

Fishing the Tide Change. 28
Light Line Jigging in Calm Conditions 29
Drift and Scan Tactic. 29
Weight and Ice for Fish Care. 30

CHAPTER 6: FLOATING LAB 31

Anchor Deployment with Control. 31

CHAPTER 7: FOR EVERY ACTION, A REACTION 32

Jigging Rod for Bait Setup. 32
Dedicated Jigging Setup. 32
PE Rating 33
My Setup 34

CHAPTER 8: PRESERVE TO SERVE 35

CHAPTER 9: FLOATING FORTRESS 38

Gear Organisation & Communal Crate. 38
Nets, Gaffs & Deck Cleanliness. 39
Protective Clothing & Final Checks 41

CHAPTER 10: BOATSIDE BITES 42

Sushi at Sea 42
Ceviche-Acid-Cooked Freshness. 42
Chicken Bops 43
Fish Tacos on the Boat 43
Braai'd Steenbras 44

CHAPTER 11: KILL THE DIRECTOR 45

Filming the Action – GoPro Tricks. 45
Structure Your Videos Like a Story. 46
Combining Tech with Tactics. 47

INTRODUCTION

Why This Book? This handbook was born out of years of real-world experience fishing the deep waters off Buffelsbaai and surrounding areas. After countless trips, successes, failures, and lessons, this guide serves as a collection of refined techniques, spot insights, seasonal patterns, and practical tips. It's written for anyone who wants to fish smarter, not harder, in one of South Africa's most exciting offshore zones.

The Buffelsbaai Advantage. Buffelsbaai, nestled between Knysna and Sedgefield on the Garden Route, offers unique access to deep sea drop-offs, rocky pinnacles, and unpressured reefs—all within manageable distances from shore. These waters are rich with Roman, Steenbras, Kob, Yellowbelly, and Musselcracker, among others. With the right approach, this stretch can yield some of the best bottom fishing on the Southern Cape coast.

What Makes Deep Sea Fishing Unique Here. Unlike some coastal areas where you're limited to sandy bottoms or long runs, Buffelsbaai gives you access to structure in a variety of depths from 20m to 80m within a 10–15km radius. The region's unique tidal flows, moon-current relationship, and bathymetric structure create dynamic conditions—making knowledge, timing, and adaptability far more important than luck.

Who This Guide Is For. Honestly? This guide is for nobody. It's not for the average fisherman, the occasional holiday rod-shaker, or the guy who buys pilchards from the petrol station. It's for me—and maybe for you if you've ever daydreamed about reef ledges and sonar arches during a family braai. Whether you're fishing baited rigs from anchor or testing the slow jig bite in 60 meters, this is a personal collection of what works, what doesn't, and what made me shout "fish on" at inappropriate volumes. No fluff. No gatekeeping. Just hard-earned knowledge for the few who care enough to dig deep.

How to Use This Book. Each chapter covers a different dimension of your fishing strategy—from reading your fishfinder to choosing bait, understanding moon phases, or anchoring like a sniper. Feel free to read it front to back, or skip straight to what matters most to you. By combining the localised knowledge inside with your own observations, you'll fish with more confidence, catch more consistently, and grow your personal understanding of this incredible coastline.

CHAPTER 1: When the Ocean Whispers

Flat vs Rough Seas: Reading the Water and the Sounder Your first decision before launching isn't which bait to bring—it's whether the sea itself is going to let you fish effectively. Flat seas are your best friend. On flat days, using bottom lock on the Garmin sonar (especially on Zoom) reveals clean, detailed structure and helps you drop precisely on fish. In rougher conditions, bottom lock becomes less reliable—auto mode might be your only option, but expect distorted bottom readings and difficulty staying on productive zones.

Big swells and strong currents are more than just uncomfortable—they make bottom fishing almost impossible. You'll constantly lose bait, snag the reef, and struggle to keep your line vertical. If it's one of those heave-and-surge days, rather have a braai.

Temperature, Wind, and Water Movement. Temperature tells a story if you know how to listen. The magic zone for Buffelsbaai fishing tends to be between 17°C and 22°C. SE winds cool the water over time, while SW winds typically warm it up. But here's the trick—winds need to blow consistently for at least three days before they actually shift the underwater temperature in a meaningful way. Don't get excited after just one warm gust. Let the weather do its thing, then strike.

Current: Your Best Ally and Worst Enemy. Moderate current can be amazing—it spreads scent, activates fish, and gets everything moving. But too much? It'll send your rig halfway to Antarctica. A ripping current will lift your line off the bottom, tangle your traces, and render even the best bait presentation useless. On the flip side, no current at all (slack tide) can feel like fishing in a bathtub—dead water, dead rods.

In Buffelsbaai, the sweet spot for current is just below medium—think of it as a 4 out of 10 if 10 is completely unfishable and 1 is dead still. That's the magic range where your line stays vertical, bait holds position, and fish actively feed without being spooked or scattered by strong surge. Most of the best catches happen in this current window. If the current is completely dead or starting to rip, don't expect much more than an underwater sightseeing trip.

Swell & Depth Interaction. In deeper water (30–40m+), a large swell can feel less severe, but it still affects boat movement, line tension, and your sonar image. Shallower reefs get stirred up quickly and can become unfishable in even moderate swell. A good rule of thumb: if the swell is under 2m and the wind is under 15 knots, you're probably good to go. Use Windy or Windguru for hyper-local forecasts.

Moon and Tide: The Invisible Hand. Understanding moon and tide is a game-changer. Fish the change of tide—just before and after high or low tide. That's when current typically softens, bait settles, and predators move in.

- New Moon: Low light, stronger current—excellent for bait fishing. Fish feed harder during the day.
- Full Moon: Visual predators feed more at night—expect slower day bites, especially on jigs.
- Quarter Moons (First & Last): Less current = easier to fish structure and finesse bait presentation.

Pairing moon and current is key. A moderate current on a spring tide (new or full moon) often produces hot bites. If you notice slack tide on a bright full moon day—don't bother with jigs, go bait-and-wait with big baits.

The Decision Formula. Ask yourself: - Is the swell under 2m? - Is the wind under 15 knots? - Has the wind been consistent for 3+ days? - Is the tide turning within the next hour or two? - Is water temp between 17°C–22°C?

If you can say yes to most of these, pack some extra bait and it's game time. If not… pack lots of beer.

CHAPTER 2: Arsenal Assembled

Your line setup can make or break your connection to a fish, especially in deep water where abrasion, stretch, and stealth all come into play. The go-to formula is: braid mainline → monofilament shock absorber leader → swivel → fluorocarbon trace. This combo gives you sensitivity, strength, and stealth. Braid slices through current, mono acts as a buffer for shock and abrasion, and fluorocarbon reduces visibility to cautious bottom dwellers.

For bait fishing, the line diameters are considerably heavier than jigging setups. Think 100lb mono for your shock leader and 60–80lb fluorocarbon for your trace. These thicker lines are abrasion-resistant against reef edges, protect against violent head shakes, and offer the durability needed for wrestling heavy bottom species out of structure.

For jigging setups, you want the opposite approach: go light. 20–30lb braid is ideal for cutting through water and keeping your jig vertical. A lighter line helps your jig move more naturally and fall quickly through the strike zone. You still want a fluorocarbon trace—not just for abrasion resistance but also to stay invisible to wary fish. If you're wondering where the stretch comes from in this setup, it shouldn't be your line—it should be **your rod**. A good, flexible jigging rod provides just enough give to absorb shock while still maintaining control.

Thinner braid performs significantly better in current—it cuts through water more cleanly and allows your rig to stay vertical, which is critical when fishing deep. Braid has zero stretch, so every bump and knock travels straight up the line to your fingers, giving you a direct connection to your bait and any curious fish.

Pro tip: use weaker fluorocarbon than your mono. This way, if you snag the reef, your trace breaks—not your whole rig. It also means fewer FG knots in a day—your sanity will thank you.

Choosing Your Weapons: Rods, Reels, and Rigs Rod choice depends on your preferred style: are you dropping bait and parking off, or working a jig actively? For bait fishing, a slow taper rod with backbone will let you absorb big headshakes and lift heavy fish. For jigs, especially Squidtrex or slow pitch, you'll want something responsive, parabolic, and not too stiff. Reels should have strong drags and high line capacity—30lb to 50lb braid is the typical sweet spot.

Jigs vs Bait. Know When to Switch Always start with bait. Let the fish tell you what's down there. If you're getting a lot of nibbles and small bites, and especially if you boat a cob or a decent Roman, there's a strong chance more of them are holding. That's your signal to drop a jig. Fish like Santers, Steenbras, and Kob respond well to jigs in light current. Red Roman—not so much. They're more likely to give a nod to a slow-drifting piece of chokka than chase down an artificial.

When the current is too strong (above that 4/10 sweet spot), forget jigs unless someone is on the motor keeping the boat in line. In most cases, bait wins when things get messy.

Bait Strategy: Size Matters Big bait gets big fish—but it also lets the small fish peck while you wait for the right bite. Use bigger baits to filter out small nuisances and increase the odds of a quality hookup. Fresh bait is king. Catch your own streepies or squid whenever possible—pilchards are fine, but fresh-caught bait sends a stronger signal through the current.

Match bait type and size to conditions:

- Warm water or low current: Try jigs or scented squid.
- Strong current: Use heavier cut bait with scent—chokka, octopus, or combo baits.

Anchoring Like a Sniper. Positioning is everything. Don't just throw the anchor and hope for the best. Map the area, mark your drop-offs and structure edges, and drop anchor gently and accurately. Rather anchor well in front of your intended fishing spot and drift back into position by letting out rope gradually on your anchor line. This gives you time to fine-tune your alignment and ensures your bait lands right in the zone when the current stabilizes.

Ideally, you want to be slightly up-current from the structure and allow your baits to drift naturally back onto it. If you miss it, lift and reset—don't waste an hour on dead ground. If you miss it, lift and reset—don't waste an hour on dead ground.

Add a chum bag to your anchor rope for extra effect. It can help build up action over time and hold fish around your baits longer.

Stay Tidy, Stay Sharp Keep a boat crate ready with essentials: lappies, pliers, buckets, knives, lip grips, spare swivels, leader line, and all your trace materials. You'll fish better and think clearer when everything's in its place.

This chapter isn't about having the fanciest gear—it's about using what works, when it works, and knowing how to adapt. Get this

CHAPTER 3: Underwater Eyes

Bottom Lock vs Auto: When and Why One of the first tricks to mastering your sonar is knowing when to use bottom lock. On flat sea days, bottom lock with zoom mode can help highlight structure details and bottom-hugging fish. In contrast, rough seas distort this view, making auto mode more stable. Use bottom lock when you're hovering over structure, and auto when you're exploring or in swell.

Interpreting the Display. Reading your sonar becomes instinctive over time. Look for:

- Tight blobs close to bottom – fish near reef (Romans, Carels)
- Suspended, blurry clouds – baitfish like mackerel
- Isolated arches or spaced marks – possibly Steenbras, Kob, or Geelbek

If the returns are small and directly over hard reef, it's likely reef residents. Bigger fish tend to mark slightly above or off the edge of structure.

Structure Is King. Focus on isolated rises, reef edges, and the front face of structure—where current hits first. This is prime territory. A 1–2 metre bump on the seabed can be enough to hold serious fish if the conditions line up.

Adjusting Sensitivity by Depth

- Shallow (20–30m): reduce gain to avoid surface clutter
- Deep (40–80m): increase sensitivity to detect subtle arches and bottom detail

Bright colour returns = rock. Soft, faint returns = sand, mud, or dead zones.

Transducer Positioning. If your sonar drops out at speed, check the transducer angle. Even a small tilt can distort readings above 12 knots. Once correctly set, you'll be able to log new structure on the move.

Marking and Notes. Always save promising sonar hits. Label them logically—"ROM34", "LEDGE62", etc. Add details like depth, temperature, current direction, and what you saw. Over time, this builds a custom map more valuable than any chart.

Train your eye to spot anomalies and subtle returns. Often, the difference between catching and cruising is seeing what others miss—and knowing it's worth dropping on.

CHAPTER 4: Underwater Chess

Red Roman. These reef dwellers prefer hard structure and don't venture far. They often sit tight to rock, rarely chasing fast-moving jigs. Best targeted with slow, natural baits like chokka or octopus strips, gently fluttered or held near the reef. Fish tight to the bottom and avoid excess movement—Romans prefer a subtle, easy meal.

Steenbras. More active than Romans, Steenbras can be caught on both bait and jigs—especially when they're feeding. They often show as large, spaced returns on sonar, sitting just above reef patches. Use big, scented baits or slow-pitch jigs in moderate current. Expect powerful, long fights and the occasional heartbreak.

Kob. Kob love sand and mixed bottom, especially around rocky patches or drop-offs. They're classic ambush predators and respond well to live bait, large chokka strips, or paddle-tail style jigs. Often mark as isolated fish or in loose schools. A good drift over a flat, broken bottom can result in multiple fish—if you find one, there are usually more.

Yellowbelly. Rockcod Highly territorial and often found in pairs, Yellowbelly sit deep in structure and rarely roam far. Use big baits and fish right into their hole—presenting bait vertically in their face often triggers a strike. Be patient, as they're cautious feeders, but strong fighters once hooked.

Musselcracker. (Black) One of the most sought-after and frustrating species. These bruisers hang around pinnacles and sharp structure, often showing as large returns in small groups or solo. They're notorious for inspecting bait without biting. Use heavily scented, tough baits and fish with minimal movement. Persistence pays.

Miss Lucy. Miss Lucy prefer deeper water and respond well during full moon phases when visual feeders slow down. They hit both bait and jigs but tend to prefer structure with soft coral or reef edges. Use medium-sized chokka or redbait, and look for subtle sonar returns near softer reef.

Santer. (Soldier Bream) Active feeders and great fun on jigs, Santers often school above reef edges. When the bite is on, you'll get hit on the drop. Use bright jigs or fresh bait and keep moving until you locate a school.

Strategic Overview - Target specific species based on structure: hard reef =

Romans, drop-offs = Kob, pinnacles = Musselcracker - Adjust tactics to current: jigs in light current, bait when things pick up - Observe sonar behaviour: spaced arches = big fish; tight fuzz = bait or smalls - Cycle techniques: bait to locate fish, then jigs for the active feeders

Every fish has a personality—some bash, some nibble, some test your patience. Matching your approach to their behaviour is half the game. Know your quarry, know your water, and your rod will do the rest.

CHAPTER 5: Tactical Edge

Filtering with Big Bait. One of the simplest but most effective strategies for upping your catch quality is using bigger bait. This doesn't just attract bigger fish—it filters out the pests. Small fish might nibble, but they won't commit. The real players—Musselcracker, Steenbras, or big Kob—will. Big bait also holds better in current and stays intact longer, especially when you're anchored and waiting for a strike.

Targeting the Front of Structure. Fish stack up on the front (up-current) side of reef or pinnacles where bait gets funnelled. Position yourself well in front of your mark and drift back slowly with anchor rope or drift line. Let your baits settle naturally onto the strike zone. Big fish wait there because they don't want to work for their food—they let the current do it for them.

Using Scent to Your Advantage. Especially on quiet days or during slack bite windows, scent can be the trigger. Soak baits in oils, use fresh bait with blood and guts intact, or scent your lures (like Squidtrex). A chum bag on your anchor is a bonus. It creates a scent trail that drifts over structure and brings curious fish into range—sometimes turning a dead drift into a feeding frenzy.

Fishing the Tide Change. Most anglers wait for high or low tide, but the real magic happens on the change itself—that transition when current slows and turns. Fish reposition, bait settles, and predators strike. Plan your best drops or bait soaks around this window—it often lasts only 30–45 minutes.

Fishing Deeper Zones (60–80m). Most boats stay in the 30–40m range, but deeper reefs are often less pressured and hold larger fish. Use heavier tackle, bigger baits, and make sure your sonar is dialled in. Look for isolated reef knobs or slow-drop ledges, and be patient—big bites are fewer but worth the wait.

Light Line Jigging in Calm Conditions. When the current drops and conditions flatten out, switch to lighter braid (20–30lb) and fluorocarbon for finesse jigging. Fish like Santer and Kob become less suspicious and more responsive to fluttering jigs. In these windows, even fish that refused bait earlier can become aggressive.

Drift and Scan Tactic. On exploratory trips, use a zig-zag drift pattern over likely ground. Watch your sonar and mark anything promising—bottom changes, isolated arches, or bait balls. Once you find a pattern, go back, anchor up (or position again), and drop with intent.

Maximise Hookups with Live Bait. If you can catch livies—do it. Mackerel, maasbanker, or streepies make phenomenal baits for Kob and Geelbek. Livies work especially well on sandy bottoms with scattered reef. Always carry a small sabiki rig or throw net for collecting live bait on the way out.

Weight and Ice for Fish Care. Fish destined for the table or comp weigh-ins should be bled immediately and kept in an ice slurry. This not only preserves flavour and texture but also adds a few hundred grams to weight—especially on species like Steenbras.

Final Thoughts. Advanced fishing is less about gear and more about thinking ahead, observing, and adjusting. These small tactical shifts—bait size, anchor position, scent, or timing—often mean the difference between coming home heavy or coming home hungry. Fish smart, fish alert, and never stop refining the approach.

CHAPTER 6: Floating Lab

The Essential Boat Crate. Your boat is your base—and a well-organised boat crate can turn chaos into calm. Pack it the same way every time so you can grab what you need without thinking. Essentials include: - Lappies or microfiber cloths (keep things clean and dry) - Buckets (for bleeding fish, bait wash, and rinsing) - Lip grips and pliers (ready for fast unhooking) - Sharp knives and spare trace line - Swivels, hooks, sinkers, leader, and bait elastic - Chum bag and rope clip

Bonus: zip-tied mesh pouches or tackle trays can be attached to the inside of the crate lid for quick access to frequently used gear.

Anchor Deployment with Control. Avoid the chaos of noisy or sloppy anchor drops. Secure your anchor line neatly and ease it out slowly, especially when targeting structure. Always drop anchor well up-current of your target and let rope out gradually to drift into position. Use marker buoys to track movement and reposition if needed. Tidy deck, tidy mind.

Jigging Rod for Bait Setup. Although primarily used for slow-pitch jigging, I often fish bait with a flexible, sensitive jig rod (PE 2–4) spooled with 40 lb braid and paired with the Oceana Jigger reel. The zero-stretch braid transmits every knock, while the rod's parabolic bend absorbs violent headshakes, guaranteeing solid hooksets and steady lifts even in heavy structure.

Dedicated Jigging Setup. My go-to jigging outfit centres on a PE 1.5 rod—light yet powerful enough for Steenbras, Kob and bigger targets. It's paired with a compact baitcaster jigging reel loaded with 20–30 lb braid. This combo gives a lightning-fast jig response, superior fall rate and enough back-bone to control fish without sacrificing feel.

PE Rating - Jig Weight Table Most South African rods specify power by jig weight (g). Use this as a quick guide when choosing or matching rods:

PE Rating	Recommended Jig Weight
PE 1	15–40 g
PE 1.5	20–60 g
PE 2	30–80 g
PE 3	50–100 g
PE 4	80–150 g
PE 5	100–200 g
PE 6	150–250 g

Rod Flexibility "'I prefer slacker rods because the parabolic bend absorbs headshakes and ensures I get solid hooksets without yanking the hook out, when a big fish explodes on the line, that flex gives just enough give to protect knots and braid, while still delivering power to slide the hook in and yank fish out of structure."

My Setup

- Bait & Jig Rod: PE 2–4 rod, 40 lb braid → mono shock → fluorocarbon trace, Oceana Jigger reel
- Jig-Only Rod: PE 1.5 rod, 20 lb braid, compact baitcaster jigging reel

Recommended Setup for Other Anglers For anglers new to deep-sea bottom fishing:

- Rod: Shimano Travala PE 2 (50–100 g cast weight)
- Reel: Shimano TwinPower 10,000 spinning reel
- Line: 30 lb braid with mono shock leader and fluoro trace

This balanced combo lets you enjoy the bite and fight fish confidently, without overwhelming beginners with ultra-light gear or risking break-offs on heavy structure.

CHAPTER 8: *Preserve to Serve*

Fishing the deep sea off Buffelsbaai is as much about stewardship as it is about skill. My guiding principle is simple: I only take home what I can eat. While it's tempting to fill the hold with every fish on the sounder—especially abundant species like deep-sea kob—I focus on sustainable choices. Deep-sea cob remains plentiful, so I keep my daily limit. In contrast, shoreline cob and vulnerable species like red Steenbras or black musselcracker are released gently to protect future breeding stock.

Once a keeper fish is in the boat, the race against time begins. The very first step is bleeding: with sharp snips just behind the gills, I sever the main arteries and then slip the fish into a livewell or bucket of seawater for eight to ten minutes. During this interval, the blood drains away, turning the flesh from a streaky pink to a pristine white and eliminating that pungent "fishy" aroma.

Traditional ice blocks cool unevenly, chilling only at contact points and leaving pockets of warmth where enzymes can spoil texture. I prefer an ice slurry: crushed ice mixed with saltwater in bagged pockets forms a brine slush that envelops every contour of the fish. Submerged in this icy bath, the fish's temperature plummets swiftly, preserving moisture, firmness, and flavour.

Gutting adds another layer of freshness, though I often skip it if I plan to fillet immediately on shore. If I do gut, it's a quick remove of entrails before returning the fish to the slurry—minimising handling and preventing contamination. When filleting, I rinse surfaces with saltwater, not tap water. Freshwater can osmose into the flesh, making it mealy and reducing protein integrity.

Competitive anglers know the value of weight retention. A fish weighed dry can shed up to half a kilogram before the afternoon weigh-in; the ice slurry prevents this loss, giving you every gram you deserve. At home, I keep fillets in the slurry until it's time to clean and portion them. Vacuum-paking for the freezer eliminates air pockets and forestalls freezer burn, but I never store beyond two weeks—beyond that, even the best pack loses its luster.

The difference between a well-cared-for fillet and one rushed onto ice is unmistakable: the former boasts bright, unblemished flesh, a delicate ocean aroma, and firm, flaky flakes that hold together on the plate. By following these simple but disciplined steps—selective harvest, meticulous bleeding, rapid cooling, minimal handling, and smart storage—you'll honour both the fish you catch and the rich coastline that sustains them.

CHAPTER 9: Floating Fortress

When you step aboard, the difference between a good day and a busted trip often comes down to preparation and teamwork. Ideally, your crew should never exceed two to four people. Two anglers offer the perfect balance—ample hands without overcrowding. More than four becomes awkward: rods tangle, space runs out, and morale dips faster than the tide.

Gear Organisation & Communal Crate. Before you shove off, gather your communal crate—a single source for all shared essentials. Keep hooks sealed in their retail packets inside a Tupperware container; this prevents rust and saves you from rummaging through soggy dividers. Store soft plastics and jigs separately in dry pouches. Encourage each angler to limit themselves to one rod if they're inexperienced; that way they can focus on mastering a reliable, all-purpose setup without tripping over extra gear. Bait Preparation & Fish Hatch Management Fresh bait is king, but cleanliness is queen. Pack pilchards only when no better option exists; live-caught streepies and leg-thick chokka outperform pillies—and

leave far less mess. Line your onboard hatch with a durable, water-resistant bag: it keeps scales and guts contained and makes post-trip cleanup an ice-cold breeze. Once you've hooked and landed a prize, always bleed your catch through the gills into a livewell or portable aerated bucket. Minutes in an ice-cold slurry of seawater and crushed ice pulls heat from the flesh faster than blocks alone, preserving texture, flavour, and weight—critical if you're eyeing the leaderboards.

Nets, Gaffs & Deck Cleanliness. A modest landing net—just large enough to guide a fish's head—prevents runaway giants without taking up valuable space. For crunch moments, a small gaff through the mouth or behind the pectoral fins seals the deal. As the deck becomes a canvas of slime, dedicate two buckets—one per side—each with a "nat-lappie". Encourage quick wipe-downs after every catch and a fresh water rinse of the floor at each stop. A tidy deck keeps the boat safe and spirits high. Sonar Mastery & Rod Holders Know your electronics inside out. A day spent trialling every GPS and sonar setting—even in a sheltered lagoon—pays dividends when you're hunting deep structure. Position rod holders at each station so rods stand upright when the bite goes from zero to frenetic;

upright rods avoid broken tips, tangle-free decks, and fumbling hands. Stainless-Steel Anchors & Breakaway Release Your anchor is more than ballast—it's a lifeline. Opt for a stainless-steel clambank anchor with 10 mm rods that flex open on contact. Attach 2–3 m of marine-grade chain to the shank, and rig a sacrificial cable-tie release: if the anchor snags irreparably, the tie breaks before your bow does. When you've pinpointed your drop—15 m up-current from structure—ease the anchor into the water. Once it bites, let out enough scope so the chain lies at a 45° angle, then snug it by gently reversing the motor. To retrieve, haul vertically whenever possible; if it hangs, have one crew at the bow guide the shank upright while the helm drives forward with a gentle arc. The surge often pops the flukes free. Always carry a length of spare pipe to bend prongs back into shape, plus extra cable ties for quick rig replacements.

Protective Clothing & Final Checks. A long-sleeve UV shirt and full-brim hat are non-negotiable, even under a blazing sun. Polarized sunglasses cut glare and reduce eye strain, helping you read both water colour and sonar returns. Don't forget buffs for neck and face protection, and choose hats with vents for airflow. Before you cast off, run through the Mental Pre-Flight: Plugs & Lines: Did you pack your plugs? Are all knots retied? Fuel & Engine: Is the tank topped up? Are the keys onboard? Safety: Are lifejackets at hand? Is the anchor system set? When every element is in its place, your mind is free to focus on the one thing that really matters: hooking the fish.

CHAPTER 10: Boatside Bites

Sushi at Sea. Bonito and Sashimi Rituals. Bonito (or bonnies) are perfect for sushi or sashimi. Bleed the fish well and keep it on ice to firm up. Slice into thin strips. Prepare sushi rice using the following recipe: rinse 1 cup of sushi rice until water runs clear, cook with 1.2 cups water, then mix with 2 tbsp rice vinegar, 1 tbsp sugar, and 1 tsp salt. Serve with wasabi, pickled ginger, and soy sauce. You can roll sushi using a mat or enjoy the sashimi straight. It's a delicious, fresh way to enjoy your catch.

Ceviche-Acid-Cooked Freshness. Ceviche is a banging way to prepare fish using acid instead of heat. Start with fresh fish—either bonito for a tuna-style sashimi or white meat fish like cob or sonner. Slice it thinly against the grain. In a bowl, mix the fish with chopped chili, coriander, red onion, lime juice (not lemon), salt, pepper, a teaspoon of fish sauce or soy sauce, and a splash of coconut milk or cream. The lime juice partially cooks the fish, creating a fresh, flavorful appetizer. Let it sit for a few minutes and serve chilled.

Chicken Bops. Deep Fried Finger Fish. This banging snack uses cob or bulk fish cut into finger-sized strips. In a ziplock bag, mix Southern Coating, flour, and lots of salt. Dip the fish in egg, then either go straight to oil or coat in breadcrumbs first. Fry in medium heat oil until golden and foamy—about 30 pieces in the pan is ideal. Undercook slightly and let them rest to finish cooking. Juicy, crispy, and perfect for sharing on the boat or at home.

Fish Tacos on the Boat. Sometimes the best way to enjoy your catch is to slow down, step out of the adrenaline rush, and cook right on the boat. If you've got the time and patience, grab a gas burner and a cast iron pot and make yourself some fish tacos. You'll need fresh fish, butter, spice, wraps, lettuce, and mayo. Fry the fish in butter with your favorite spice mix until golden. Warm the wraps, layer with crispy fish, shredded lettuce, and a dollop of mayo. It's a moment of calm in the chaos of chasing fish.

Braai'd Steenbras – Skin Down, Flavor Up. For a proper braai, take a whole Steenbras, remove the head, and flapper it open down the middle. Leave the fins and bones intact. Place it skin-side down on the grill for about 20 minutes on low to medium heat depending on thickness. Flip for 3–5 minutes on the non-skin side for color. Never overcook—slightly underdone with a shiny center is perfect. Baste with a mix of butter, fish spice, salt, pepper, lemon juice, cream, and crushed garlic. Apply the basting throughout the cook, especially after flipping. Let the fish rest for 5 minutes, then flake it open and pour the remaining sauce between the layers. Serve directly from the tray—guests will love the show and the flavor.

CHAPTER 11: Kill The Director

Filming the Action – GoPro Tricks. To capture the moments you'll want to relive later, you need a clean, consistent filming plan: - GoPro on your head: POV shots that follow your line and rod movement - Side pole or clamp mount: Get a wide-angle perspective of the deck and the action - Record everything: Don't wait for the bite—record the searching, prepping, and talking too

Keep the Energy Up. Viewers (even if it's just future-you) want engagement. Be loud, be confident—say things like "What's cooking!" or "We're on!" to keep the vibe alive. Narrate what you're seeing on the sonar or why you're changing bait. Share the thought process.

Structure Your Videos Like a Story. Follow a simple, repeatable format: - Intro: Hook the viewer (ask a question, hint at a secret) - Problem: What's the challenge today? - Search/Struggle: Drift, scout, drop, test - Result: The hook-up, the fight, the fish - Outro: Wrap-up and key takeaways

Keep it under 10 minutes for punchiness. Edit with variety—zoom-ins, voiceovers, and different angles. Add subtitles for key moments or explanations.

Building a Footage Archive. Store and sort your footage right after every trip: - Organise by date and conditions (e.g., "2025-06-12_Steady_SEwind_18C") - Keep a "Stock Footage" folder for general use: drone shots, ocean surface, gear close-ups - Back up files to external drives or cloud services

This archive becomes your long-term visual fishing log and marketing toolkit.

Combining Tech with Tactics. Use your footage not just to tell stories, but to review your technique. Watch your drift angle, how quickly you hook up after sonar marks, or how fish behave once hooked. It becomes a tool for improvement.

Having the right gear and strategy is half the game—recording it with purpose turns every trip into something bigger. Whether it's to share with others or sharpen your own skills, a thoughtful filming setup makes every drop count.